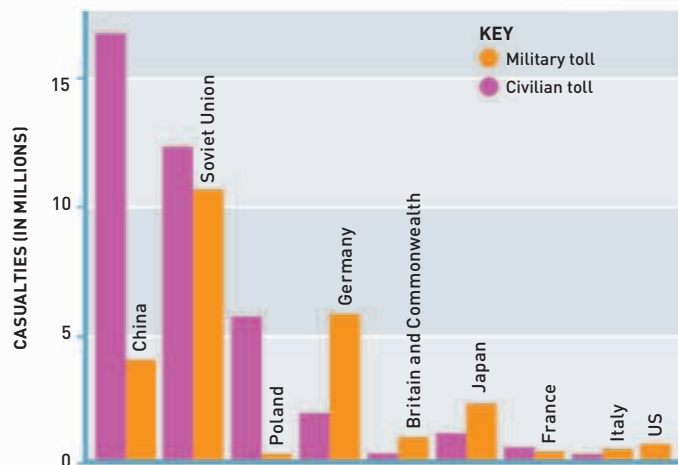




A formally dressed Japanese delegation prepares to sign the surrender papers on board the American battleship USS *Missouri* in Tokyo Bay on September 2.



World War II casualties

More civilians than servicemen died in World War II. The Soviet Union and Germany had the heaviest military death tolls. Poland lost one in five of its population, including most Polish Jews.

His body and that of his mistress Clara Petacci were hung upside down from meat hooks in a Milan gasoline station.

The **surrender of German forces** was complete by **May 8**, sparking heartfelt victory celebrations in Allied countries. Although war continued with Japan, the British Labour Party withdrew from the wartime coalition to fight a general election against the Conservatives led by Churchill. To general astonishment, **Labour** won a **landslide victory**, their promise of a welfare state and democratic

socialism outweighing the popular appeal of Churchill's war record.

On July 16, the New Mexican desert was lit up by the **world's first atomic explosion**. This was the culmination of the top-secret **Manhattan Project**, a feat of science and engineering that had cost America \$2 billion, spent on presidential authority without Congressional approval. The explosion produced temperatures higher than those at the core of the sun.

The successful atomic test coincided with the gathering of Allied leaders for a conference at Potsdam, a Berlin suburb. Although differences

between the Western Allies and the Soviet Union were growing, Stalin agreed to join in the war on Japan. At the end of the conference the Allies issued the **Potsdam Declaration**, calling on Japan to surrender immediately or face "prompt and utter destruction." The **Japanese government rejected the call to surrender** as "of no important value."

Preparations for dropping atom bombs on Japanese cities were well advanced even before the first atomic test. The first bomb was dropped on **Hiroshima** as soon as it was ready and weather conditions permitted (see panel, right). Three days later, on August 9, a second bomb devastated the city of **Nagasaki**, killing at least 35,000 people. The **Soviet invasion of Manchuria** was a further shock to Japan.

Since June, the Japanese government had been split between those who wanted a negotiated peace and militarists insisting on a fight to the death. On August 10 **Emperor Hirohito intervened decisively in favor of the peace faction**. The Japanese agreed to



HIROSHIMA

The American B-29 bomber, *Enola Gay*, piloted by Colonel Paul Tibbets, took off from Tinian Island in the Marianas at 2:45 on the morning of August 6 carrying an atom bomb. It dropped the bomb on the Japanese port-city of Hiroshima at 8:15. Heat, light, and the explosion killed some 70,000 people instantly. The lingering effects of radiation raised total deaths to an estimated 140,000.

surrender if the status of the emperor was guaranteed. Although Truman refused to offer any such assurance, on August 15 Hirohito told his people the war had developed "not necessarily to Japan's advantage," and that he was making peace.

The **war had ended** with unexpected suddenness. Dealing with the **aftermath** of devastated cities, broken economies, occupied enemy countries, refugees ("displaced persons"), and war criminals posed almost as great a challenge as the war itself.



Time of death

A pocket watch retrieved from the body of a citizen of Hiroshima records the exact moment when the atom bomb exploded above the city.

Raising the red flag

Taken by a Red Army photographer, this photo reconstructs the moment when soldiers raised the Soviet flag on the Reichstag building in Berlin.

